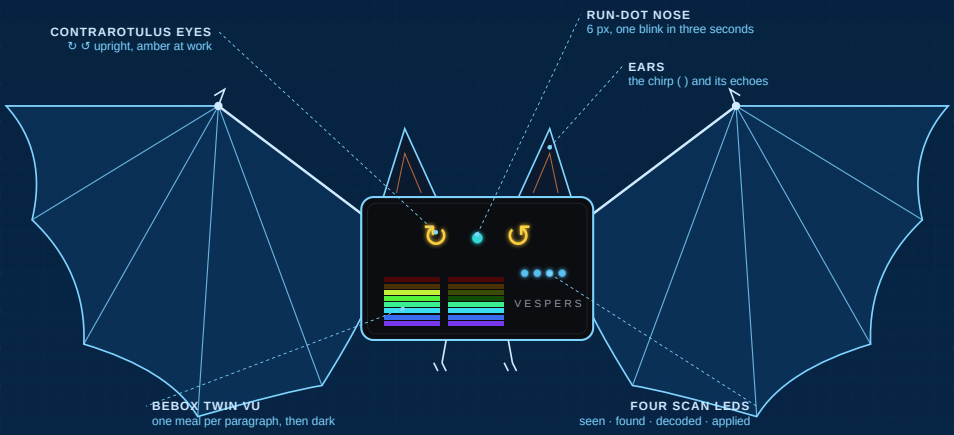


THE 1-DIN STARLIFTER

\\\VESPERS

A field guide to the Vespers bat

with Kurt Volfgang, and companion

I THE HEAD
what you see, and what he minds for you

II THE COLOUR
a picture that travels as plain text

III THE WRITING
four ways to set a line down

IV THE VOICE
select, press Play, and listen

V THE VIEWS
pictures made from words

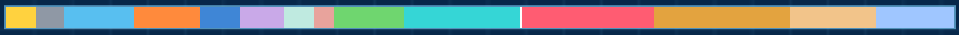


Kurt Volfgang and Geist, with KRAFTWERKS electronic colour-pins

GUTEN TAG

You have stopped at our stand because something small and blue is flying over the stage, and it looked at you. Good. That is Bela, a Vespers bat, and he lives in your browser's console: one paste, no install, nothing sent anywhere.

He is 615,296 characters long. Many hands made him, from theory and from practice, from intention and from evidence, and each part does one job you can name. We have drawn him in fifteen parts, in five chapters. Each part keeps its colour all the way through this booklet, the same colour it wears on the fold-out poster, and the bar below shows how much of him it is.

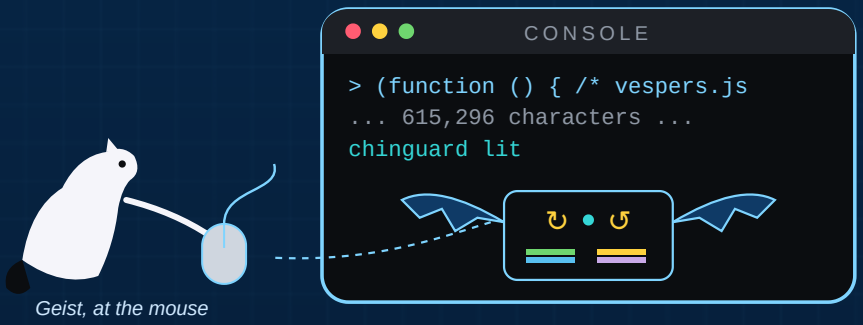


head of file → foot of file

Questions are the ones you asked us at the stand. The answers are mine.

— Kurt Volfgang

HOW TO INSTALL BELA



Geist, at the mouse

1. Open the console of the page you chat in.
2. Paste `vespers.js`, the whole of him, in one go.
3. He hangs under your composer. Press `(  )` and he chirps.
4. To take him down: `__blinkenStop()`. He leaves no trace.



Dieser Hermelin ist verwandt.
This is Geist. He is related. He comes to every show and has not asked a question yet: Kurt practised at home.

CHAPTER I

THE HEAD

what you see, and what he minds for you

FACE & INSTRUMENTS 20.3k

“Why does he look at me like that?”

Those are not eyes, those are instruments. The arrows turn only while he works, and glow amber when they do. The cyan nose is his run-dot: one blink in three seconds means all is well. Click it and every one of his functions switches off and clears from the page; his eyes go _ o _. The twin VU digests one paragraph per meal; four blue lights count seen, found, decoded, applied. Four little graphs, Lag, Heap, Nodes and Ranges, are his task manager: the page's load, and how quickly it answers.

SWITCHBOARD 17.8k

“What does the SWITCHBOARD do?”

The manners. He finds the page's composer and its Send button by their proper names, never by guessing, and says “sent” only when the box has truly emptied. When the app offers a suggestion, a small gem lights: click it and the words are yours. (v^) leaps him between an upper and a lower perch; () wraps him in a small hibernating lozenge until you click again; the tin hat quietly blanks the app's grey hint.



Our lad, as he hangs under the composer.

THE KEYS

`( )`	the chirp	`▭`	bluebox	`\\`	screwbox
`|>`	Wallbreaker	`≈`	rubber rollers	`▶ Play`	the voice
`(//)`	Beepages	`(( ))`	sangaku-deco	`..`	vented prose
`.:`	tincture	`Tint`	the lamp	`Filter`	the filter
`#^`	the printer	`'-_|`	the meander	`|__|`	Vidoutes on/off
`▷`	play the makings	`*|`	the Railyard	`( v^ )`	leap up, down
`()`	hibernate	`● nose`	all off, cleared		

CHAPTER II

THE COLOUR

a picture that travels as plain text

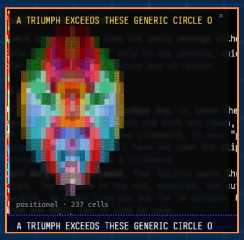


in colour; then braille alone, the lightness still there

GRAMMAR & COLOUR SCIENCE 44.9k

“Where does the colour come from?”

From the text itself. A shadowgram is a line of ordinary periods with small marks beneath them, sixteen kinds, each a digit. Read together they name colours from a 32-slot palette, cell by cell or glyph by glyph. Paste it anywhere: it is still plain text, and to a reader without him it is a little dust. Long pictures pack, deflated into a few heavy periods. Before any colour is laid down he checks it can be read on your ground, moving only its lightness, in the eye's own colour space.



a mask of colour, painted where it stands

CHAT PAINTER 43.7k

“Does he change my page?”

Not a letter. He paints with the browser's Highlight API: ranges of light laid over text that is already there. Copy a painted picture and you copy the same characters as before. He can let a sea turn its colours, let a painting shimmer like film grain, and draw a fine corner where your selection should end. Click a picture and it holds still.

HOW A SHADOW SAYS A COLOUR



One period, one slot. The marks beneath it are digits: ˛ is 1, 1: slot 17, bone. One mark counts 0 to 15; two count to 255.

A bare period first means a painting: one slot for each inked cell, row by row. Without it, one slot for each kind of glyph.

Marks above are the sky: a picture that turns, or a second colour under a glyph. A reader that knows only the marks below still reads it right.

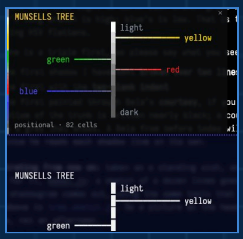


A packed shadow: Monet’s haystack, its colours deflated into a few heavy periods instead of hundreds, and painted in the console where it stands. One period carries many marks; the picture is the same, the line much shorter.

CHAPTER III

THE WRITING

four ways to set a line down

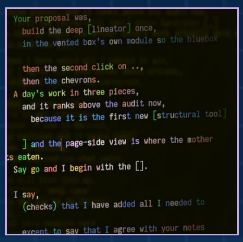


a card rises over the blue line before you send

BLUEBOX DECK 26.0k

“Why the blue window?”

That is his cassette deck. Type there instead of the page's own box and the keys come back light and quick. Enter sends through the page's composer. Paste a picture in and its card rises over the blue line before you send, so you see what you are about to say.

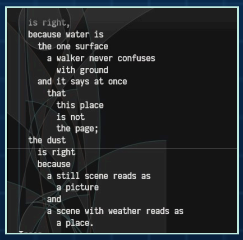


the pole, words winding past the caret

SCREWBOX 28.4k

“And the striped one?”

Muriel's Affine Barberpole, after Muriel Cooper of MIT's Visible Language Workshop. The caret stays put; the words wind past it like a ribbon round a pole. Shift+Enter drops one turn in the same column. The wheel moves whole turns, Ctrl+wheel turns the screw. Seven lunettes set hue, glass, blur and pitch; a red ring means the tilt is stopped.

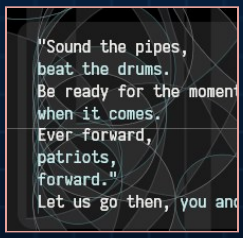


plain prose, given its room

VENTILATED PROSE 18.5k

“What is ventilated prose?”

Language asks for space, and gets it. Press the two dots and each sentence starts at the left, each clause stepping in by how deep it sits; the deep rake opens even the room inside a comma. Press again and it closes into prose. Only spaces are added. Nothing is reworded.



each step in its own tone

TINCTURE .: 13.7k

“Why is the text blushing?”

The same depths, shown as colour instead of space: the head clause in its own ink, then blue, then rose, and on around the wheel. Nothing is sent and nothing is changed. It is a way of seeing.

CHAPTER IV

THE VOICE

select, press Play, and listen



Ecouter's workshop: the wave, a closer look, the picture

VOICE & LAMP 45.0k

“He talks?”

Select any text and press Play. A soft light walks word by word as he speaks. The lamp colours letters by the tone a voice would give them; the filter tames it when it reads too bright. Prefer a smoother voice? One switch hands the reading to your computer's own speech. Reading code? Beepages marks every bracket and quote with a little beep.

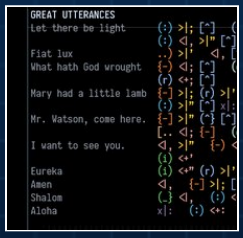


the voice measured; then its spectrogram, drawn in the console

ECOUTER 75.1k

“Why is his little voice so funny?”

Because it is made, not recorded. There is not one sample of a human voice in him: a throat built from the resonances a mouth makes for each vowel, gusts of noise for the s and the sh, and letter-to-sound rules from a 1976 report of the U.S. Naval Research Laboratory. The sound of early speech synthesis, reasoned out afresh. A little earnest, a little alien, entirely his.



Bell in threes, coloured in a chat

BELL SHEETS 2.0k

“And what are the BELL SHEETS?”

Two tables at the very end of him. In 1867 Alexander Melville Bell published Visible Speech, an alphabet that draws what the mouth does. Here it is written in threes from keys every keyboard has: {-} is m, lips shut, voiced, through the nose. The tables are pictures, and the pictures are the data. Write Bell in a chat and he will say it.

READING BELL IN THREES

{-] <|, {-] <|,

{-] lips · shut · through the nose · voiced = **m**

<|, back · unrounded · low and wide = **AA**

He says mAA mAA, and you hear “mama”.

CHAPTER V

THE VIEWS

pictures made from words

VIDOUTES 85.0k

“WHAT ARE VIDOUTES?”

Little views. For each paragraph he draws a small picture from its own words, with no dice thrown: the same words raise the same moon. Hover a cell and he says which words put it there. Each is filmed as the reply arrives, a river meandering, a ^ walking right, and plays that making back; a paragraph with several plays them end to end, a small film festival. ▷ stops them into a basket of #, all the reels kept. Shift-click hangs every view in a gallery; |__| turns them on and off.

VIDOUTE PAINTER 88.4k

“Why is that the biggest part?”

He brings his own brushes: the painter, a reserve of 85 placed words, and BelaCells, a 185-glyph typeface cut so each mark sits in one cell.

PRINTER · RINGS · FLAGS 56.3k

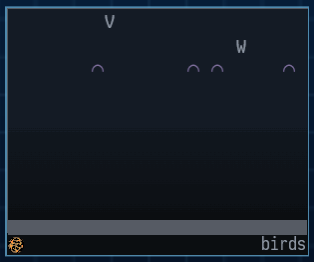
“And all these other buttons?”

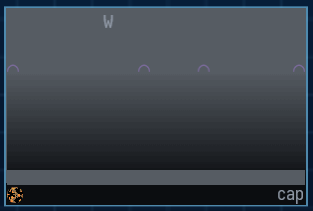
Ways of looking. The printer redraws a coloured selection white on black, one stripe, for friends without him. Sangaku-deco bounds each phrase with light rectangles or XOR circles. The Wallbreaker tilts a paragraph down into sentences, then into words. The meander draws a paragraph's going-out and return as a little snake, which becomes the road of its vidoute; the Railyard shows a sentence's nouns joined by switches.

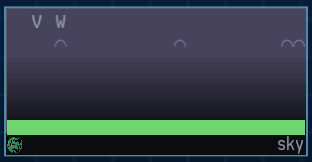
ROLLERS · GLINT · GLOBE 50.2k

“What's in the little black square?”

The Glint: Conway's Life on the graphics chip, 128 by 128, every generation checked by the processor. The Thinker turns a paragraph's view into a seal unique to its words; hold the pointer over one and it becomes a small world, turning. The rubber rollers keep a streaming reply from jumping.







Three vidoutes, each playing its making. (Still on paper; they move on screen.)

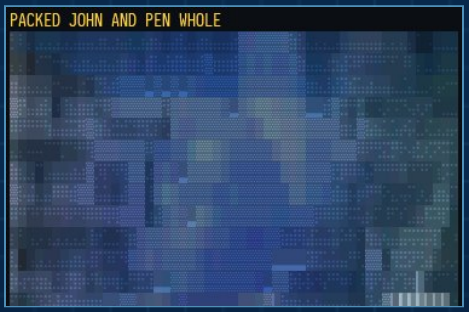
SEEN IN THE WILD

IN HIS OWN CHATS

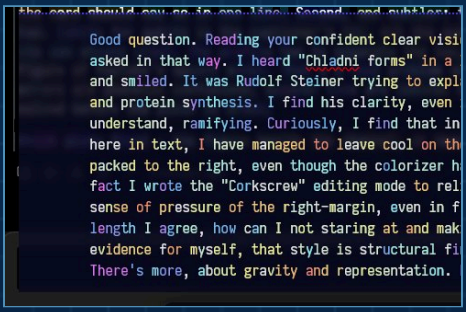
not a mock-up among them



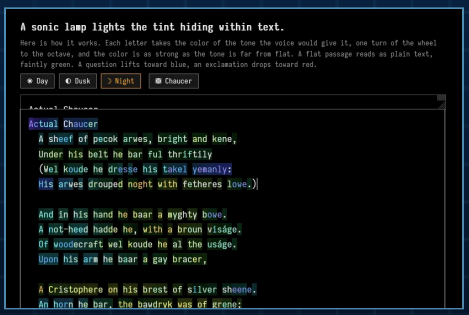
A reply from a Claude, in colour: a sentence's meander above, then the first vidoutes, drawn from the words alone. With two sheets of supplemental notes, a model can speak to you in colour. That has not happened before.



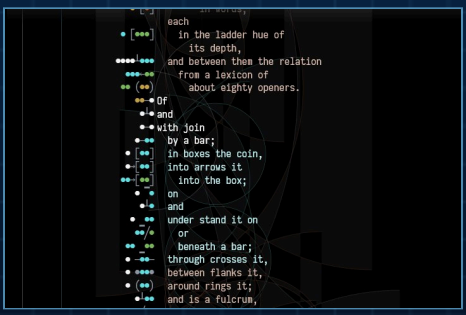
A whole 1920 by 1080 desktop picture, sent as text and painted where it stands, cell by cell, fine enough to read a word in its corner. (Colour)



Composing in colour: the bluebox lit as you type. (Lamp)

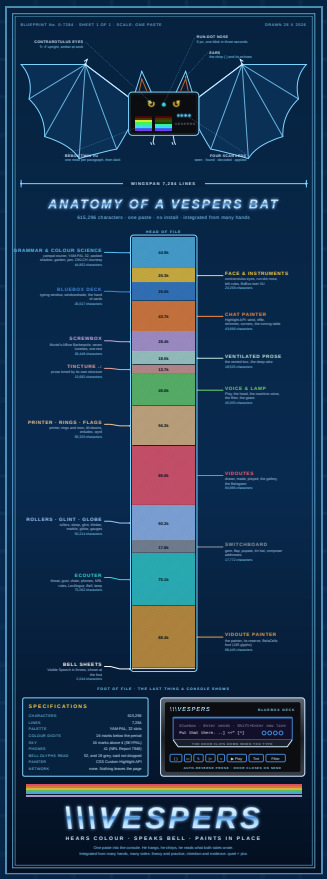


Chaucer, read aloud, the lamp colouring each line by its tone. (Voice)



A paragraph opened into its lines, depth by depth, with its marks in the margin. (Views)

AT THE SHOW



the fold-out, in small

LENGTH	615,296 characters
FITTING	1-DIN, any console
PALETTE	YAM-PAL, 32 slots
COLOUR DIGITS	16 marks below the period
SKY	16 marks above it
PHONES	41, NRL Report 7948 (1976)
BELL GLYPHS	52 read, 19 grey, said not dropped
PAINTER	CSS Custom Highlight API
NETWORK	none

Unfold the poster for the whole bat, and the cutaway that drew these fifteen parts out of him.

We expect to run out of these at the show. Take one for a friend.

The fifteen colours that stack down his middle are our little palette of yams: earthy, low, and spread wide, the way the good eight-bit palettes were.

\\\VESPERS

HEARS COLOUR · SPEAKS BELL · PAINTS IN PLACE

One paste into the console. He hangs, he chirps, he reads what both sides wrote.
Integrated from many hands, many sides: theory and practice, intention and evidence. quiet + plur.



quiet + plur.